

Psalms 8

Majesty and Human Dignity

What is man, that thou art mindful of him?

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 • THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 O LORD our Lord, how excellent is thy name in all the earth! who hast set thy glory above the heavens.
- 2 Out of the mouth of babes and sucklings hast thou ordained strength because of thine enemies, that thou mightest still the enemy and the avenger.
- 3 When I consider thy heavens, the work of thy fingers, the moon and the stars, which thou hast ordained;
- 4 What is man, that thou art mindful of him? and the son of man, that thou visitest him?
- 5 For thou hast made him a little lower than the angels, and hast crowned him with glory and honour.
- 6 Thou madest him to have dominion over the works of thy hands; thou hast put all things under his feet:
- 7 All sheep and oxen, yea, and the beasts of the field;
- 8 The fowl of the air, and the fish of the sea, and whatsoever passeth through the paths of the seas.
- 9 O LORD our Lord, how excellent is thy name in all the earth!

2 • CONTEXT

A creation-hymn of David. God's name is excellent in all the earth; His glory is above the heavens; yet He crowns frail humanity with dominion. Henry marvels at the condescension of the Creator. The New Testament applies the psalm to Christ as the true Son of Man (Heb 2:6–9; cf. Matt 21:16 on v. 2).

3 • VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-2

Opening and closing refrain: excellent name in all the earth; glory above the heavens. Strength ordained from children's mouths silences the enemy—God uses the weak to still the avenger.

Verse 3-4

Contemplation of moon and stars leads to wonder: what is man that God is mindful of him, or the son of man that God visits him? Scale produces humility, not despair.

Verse 5-8

Answer: made a little lower than the angels (or heavenly beings), crowned with glory and honor, given dominion over works of God's hands—flocks, beasts, birds, fish. Royal stewardship is gift, not self-made status.

Verse 9

The refrain returns: excellence of the Lord's name in all the earth. Worship brackets anthropology.

4 • MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

God's majesty does not erase human worth; it grounds it. We are small before the cosmos yet honored as stewards under God. Ultimate fulfillment is in Christ, the true Man who recovers dominion through humility and exaltation.

Application for life today.

Practice Psalm 8 wonder: look up and ask verse 4 without cynicism. Treat people—including yourself—as crowned image-bearers, not products. Exercise dominion as care (creation, work, relationships), not exploitation. Let children's simple praise remind you that God silences evil through unlikely strength.

5 • REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no "right length" answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. When you last considered the heavens, did it lead you toward worship or toward feeling worthless—and how does verse 5 correct that?

2. Where is God calling you to steward “dominion” as care rather than control?

3. How does seeing Christ as the true fulfillment of Psalm 8 deepen your trust or humility?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).